quantum gravity, with the ultimate goal of describing the entire universe, including its origin, in the still more disreputable nascent field of quantum cosmology. He enlisted Charlie Misner, Everett's friend, in this work. "Everyone talking with Wheeler at that time was likely to be encouraged to think about quantum gravity," recalled Misner. Everett's interest in fundamental problems in quantum theory—and his obvious talent—made Wheeler a natural choice to be Everett's advisor.

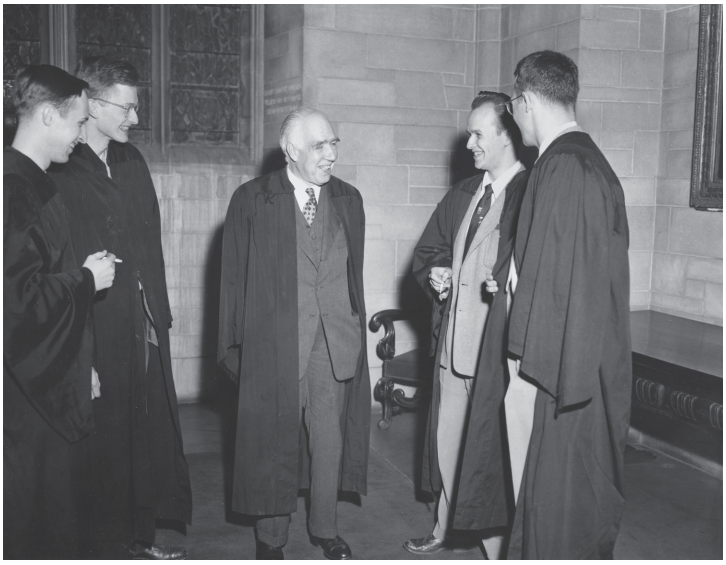


Figure 6.1. Bohr at Princeton in 1954. From left to right: Misner, Trotter, Bohr, Everett, and David Harrison.

But the influence of Wheeler and his own taste for paradoxes weren't the only reasons Everett was interested in the measurement problem. Everett's competitive nature was also at play—and his opponent this time was the assistant of Niels Bohr himself. In the fall of 1954, during Everett's second year at Princeton, Bohr came to the Princetitute for four months. He brought with him his assistant, Aage Petersen, a Danish physicist only a few years older than Everett. Everett became friends with Petersen, and, through him, he gained access to Bohr. That fall, Arnold saw Everett wandering the Princeton campus with Petersen and Bohr, lost in conversation. When Bohr lectured on campus, Everett and Misner attended. They heard the old quantum master dismiss the idea of a "quantum theory of measurement" as wrongheaded.

Around the same time, Everett passed his qualifying exams and started